

► Miraculous rain

This Mughal miniature shows Indra, a sky god and the most popular deity in Vedic times, fighting Vritra, a demonic personification of drought. At the end of their battle, Indra cut open Vritra's stomach with the *vajra*, his magic thunderbolt, releasing the waters back down to the earth.



LORE OF THE PANTHEON

ancient Hindu magic

Over the long history of Hinduism, a complex pantheon and set of philosophical beliefs arose. Followers developed a number of incantations and rituals that they believed provided a way to influence and appease the *devas* (gods) and access their divine world.

Gods and demons

Hinduism is thought to have begun among the Aryan peoples who established themselves in northern India after the Indus Valley civilization faded away in around 1500 BCE. A warrior people with a love of music and drink, the Aryans worshipped a sky god called Varuna, and drank *soma*, a ritual drink made by extracting the juice from a plant of the same name. They believed that the drink granted immortality,

stimulated courage, and cured diseases. Later, from about 1500–500 BCE, Hindus developed a set of scriptures called the *Vedas* which include accounts of the birth of the universe, battles between heroes and demons, and invocations to *devas*. Over time the caste system emerged, with Brahmin priests, the highest-ranking caste, passing their role from father to son. They ensured that people followed rituals and performed sacrifices in the prescribed manner.

Hindu scriptures

In the *Vedas*, the *devas* were identified with positive power, and their adversaries the *asuras* (demons) with destructive force. The powers of the *asuras* were often said to be great—the demon Maricha, for instance, transformed himself into a gazelle to